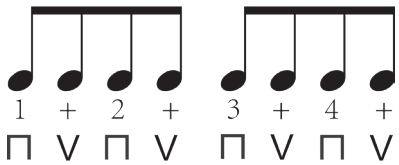
LESSON 7: UPSTROKES AND STRUMMING TECHNIQUE

It's time to finally introduce the upstrum, which is notated with a "V" sign. However, I'd encourage you to think of it as "U" for "Up" The down symbol is notated with a ⊓ symbol. Start practicing them side-by-side, strumming a simple measure of steady eighth notes with no accents. Tap your foot on the downbeats and let your pick strum down-up-down-up.

⊓ = Downstrum
V = Upstrum



Although this exercise is extremely simple, it will take many hours of practice to develop to get it sounding and feeling smooth in both directions.

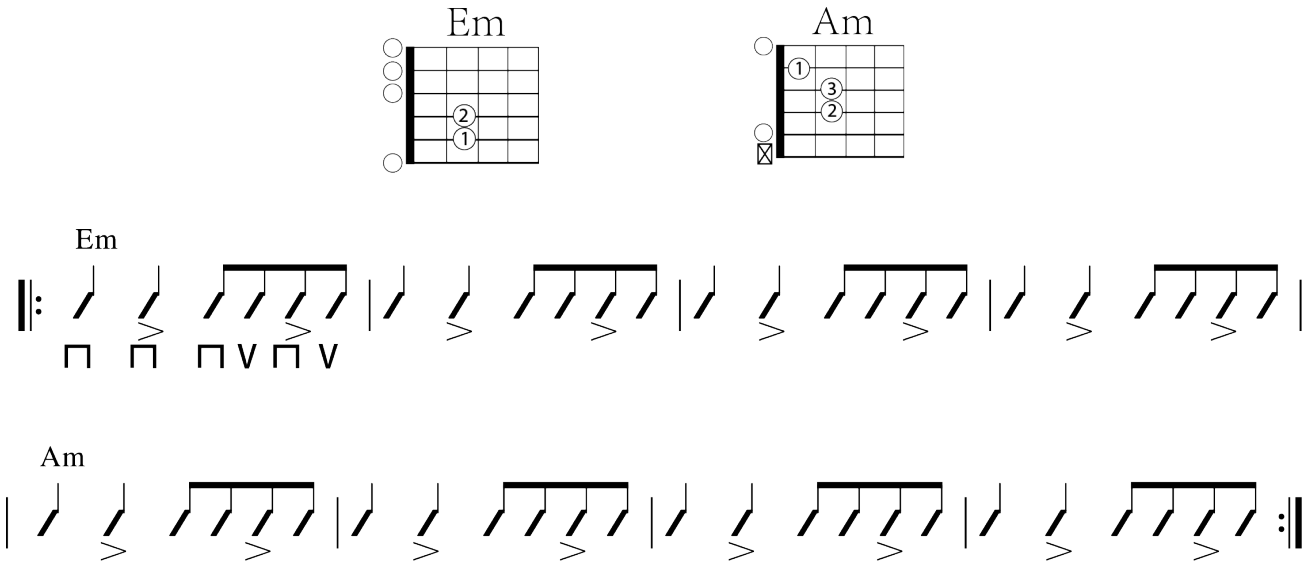
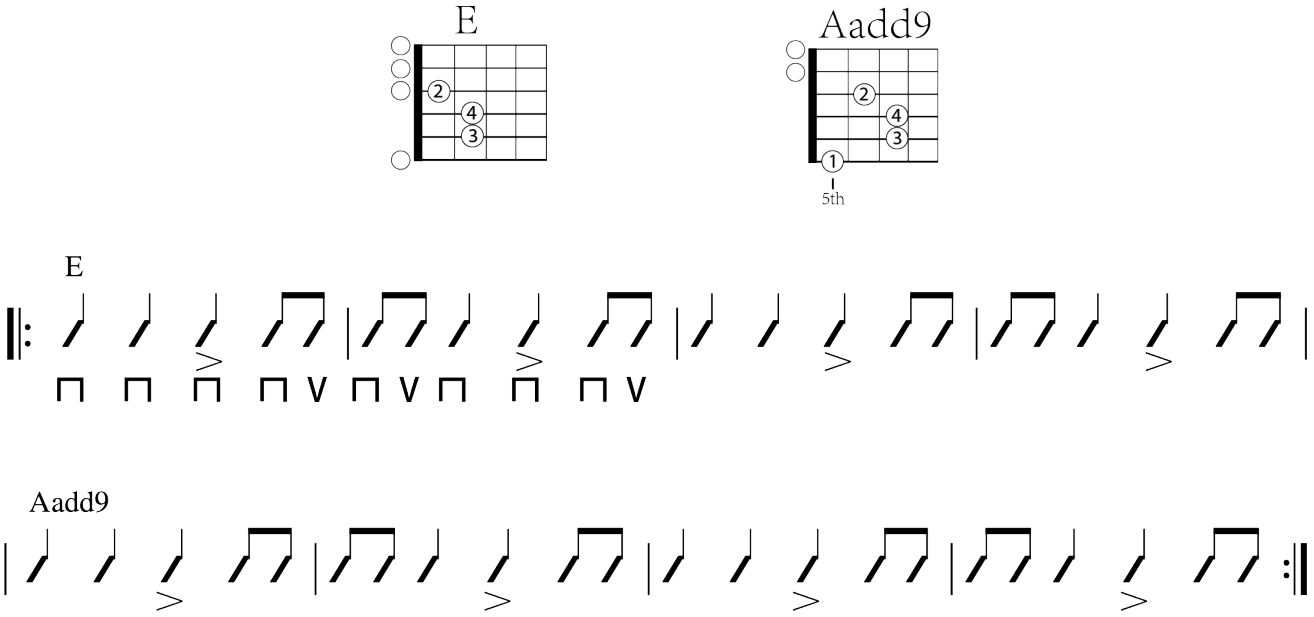
Technique

When strumming down, the pick should be angled slightly upward toward the ceiling. During upstrums, the opposite is true. This prevents the pick from getting caught on the strings and helps create a smoother sound.

However, the pick should not simply move in a pure up and down fashion. Instead, it should sketch out a gentle shallow arc that bottoms out right near the strings you're intending to hit. To create this motion, start by twisting your forearm in a spindle-like fashion, while maintaining a slight bend in the wrist. Add a slight amount of arm movement (generated from the elbow, up and down), and you have a strum that can contact all the strings without digging into them.

While you'll need to grip the pick tightly, it's import to keep the arm and wrist loose at all times. A stiff arm or hand will result in chunky, loud, and uneven strums that dig into the strings.

Throughout all of this, remember that you needn't strum every string on every strum! It's common to only strike the high (thin) strings during upstrums while focusing more on the low (thick) strings during down-strums.

For the next two exercises, begin by writing in the proper counts. For example, the first measure is 1 2 3 + 4 +. Then, play both exercises with and without accents. Count out loud the whole time while tapping your foot. Your priority is not speed, but to develop a consistent and smooth strum.

Note: the rhythmic symbols shown here are still quarter notes and eighth notes, but are displayed using a simplified style that is common in jazz fakebooks and tablature transcriptions.